

Re-Nationalizing Epistemic Authority: Speech Acts, Rule Production, and Democratic Backsliding

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This article examines the epistemic–political shift from the academic “Science Wars” of the 1990s to contemporary scientific denialism embedded in populist and re-nationalizing politics. It argues that the transformation is structural rather than merely ideological: a redefinition of who is authorized to constitute the relationship between truth, authority, and security. During the Science Wars, disputes between scientists and scholars in Science and Technology Studies unfolded within a shared symbolic universe in which science remained a legitimate epistemic institution. Critical interventions functioned primarily as assertive speech acts generating rules of instruction about the social character of scientific knowledge, without mobilizing mass constituencies or seeking institutional displacement.

By contrast, contemporary populist and re-nationalizing movements deploy climate skepticism and anti-scientific mobilization as rule-producing speech acts embedded in security narratives that frame expertise as a threat to national sovereignty and economic freedom. Through directives encouraging resistance and commissives pledging institutional reversal, these movements seek to generate new formal institutional arrangements and informal norms of epistemic validation. This reordering restructures epistemic authority and contributes to democratic backsliding by redistributing decision-making capacity within the state.